

Ole Miss - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-20 caliber with a high-end offensive backfield; playoff-level ceiling but less continuity than the 2025 result suggests
Preseason consensus	AP No. 9 (1102 points) · Conference poll SEC No. 3 (6 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 16
Returning production	61% (No. 28) overall · Off. 61% (No. 41) · Def. 62% (No. 26)
Primer power rating	+16.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.2 wins · most likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse - Slightly worse, still nationally dangerous
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: OC John David Baker keeps a fast, physical offense around QB Trinidad Chambliss and RB Kewan Lacy while the receiver hierarchy resets. HC Pete Golding still calls a defense replacing major front and safety production.

Bottom line: Ole Miss has enough proven star power to remain a top-20 team, but a brutal schedule and concentrated turnover at receiver, safety and the defensive front make another 13-win season a much harder standard than the preseason ranking implies.

Beats expectations if: Chambliss and Lacy sustain elite backfield efficiency, the rebuilt receiver hierarchy produces two reliable major targets, and the safety/front-seven portal additions settle quickly enough for Golding to keep the defense in the top-25 range.

Disappoints if: The new receiver mix cannot replace the departed production, safety remains a weekly coverage problem, and front-seven turnover reduces pressure just as the schedule reaches Texas, Georgia and Oklahoma.

Five things to remember

- 1 ★ **QB Trinidad Chambliss:** QB Trinidad Chambliss and RB Kewan Lacy return as the proven offensive centerpieces; both carry major preseason recognition, and Lacy is a first-team national All-America signal.
- 2 **Receiver room:** The receiver room is a rebuild around WR Deuce Alexander after major departures, with five notable transfers competing for the target order.
- 3 ◆ **New staff:** Pete Golding is the new head coach but still intends to call the defense; John David Baker is the offensive designer/play-caller, so the staff change preserves more game-day continuity than the titles alone suggest.
- 4 **Returning production:** Cornerback continuity is strong, but safety replaces three 2025 starters and the front seven loses several material contributors, making defensive continuity uneven despite 62% returning production.
- 5 **Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No. 8; the four-game run at Texas, Auburn, Georgia and at Oklahoma is the season-defining stress test.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	13-2 (8-1 SEC)	● Excellent
Scoring	36.9 PPG	● Elite
Total offense	489.7 YPG	● Elite
Rush offense	176.3 YPG · 4.6 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass efficiency	8.99 YPA · 26 TD / 8 INT	● Very good
Third downs	43.1%	● Good / above average
Scoring defense	21.1 PPG allowed	● Good / above average
Total defense	348.0 YPG allowed	● Good / above average
Rush defense	149.1 YPG · 4.1 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	198.9 YPG · 6.52 YPA · 17 TD allowed	● Very good

Ole Miss paired elite scoring and yardage production with a strong, not dominant, defense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+10.72 · No. 7	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.214 · No. 9	● Elite
Off. success rate	48.6% · No. 15	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	14.2% · No. 25	● Very good
Havoc allowed	13.4% · No. 36	● Good / above average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+6.05 · No. 21	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.101 · No. 27	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	38.6% · No. 35	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.4% · No. 34	● Very good
Havoc created	16.3% · No. 51	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: The offense was truly elite, ranking top-15 in adjusted offense, EPA/play and success rate. The defense was good but less disruptive, making the rebuilt front and safety group the larger 2026 concern.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / defensive play-caller	♦ Pete Golding - promoted internally from DC; retains defensive calling responsibility; from Ole Miss Defensive Coordinator	● ↔ Head-coach transition, but defensive calling remains stable
OC / offensive play-caller	♦ John David Baker - rehired from outside the staff from East Carolina OC; current offensive designer/play-caller	● ↔ New structure with an established offensive caller
DC	♦ Bryan Brown - promoted internally from co-DC/secondary; Golding remains primary defensive caller; from Ole Miss Co-Defensive Coordinator/Secondary	● ↔ Coordinator transition; Golding remains primary caller

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ WR Johntay Cook II	Syracuse	● ↔ High-upside transfer in an unsettled receiver competition.
♦ WR Darrell Gill Jr.	Syracuse	● ↔ Material receiver addition competing for a major role behind/with WR Deuce Alexander.
♦ OL Carius Curne	LSU	● ↔ Adds credible competition to an experienced OL.

Out	To	Loss
WR De'Zhaun Stribling	NFL (San Francisco), Round 2, No. 33	● ↓ Major 2025 starting receiver and 711-yard producer departs.
WR Harrison Wallace III	NFL (Arizona), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material 2025 receiver leaves.
WR Cayden Lee	Missouri	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 receiver/start role exits, increasing dependence on a new target hierarchy.
OL Jayden Williams	NFL (Arizona), Round 7, No. 217	● ↓ The NFL-bound OL loss reduces continuity even though multiple starters return.
TE Dae'Quan Wright	NFL attempt; later portal re-entry	● ↔ Another meaningful receiving TE leaves after a complicated pro/portal path.

Offensive net: ● ↓ still strong but modestly less proven than 2025

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ DT Jehiem Oatis	Colorado	● ↔ Key interior addition around returning DT Will Echoles.
♦ DE Blake Purchase	Oregon	● ↔ Adds edge/pass-rush competition.
♦ LB Keaton Thomas	Baylor	● ↑ Proven high-volume addition beside LB Suntarine Perkins.
♦ S Joenel Aguero	Georgia	● ↔ One of the primary additions in an open safety rebuild replacing three starters.

Out	To	Loss
DE Princewill Umanmielen	LSU	● ↓ Material first-unit/major-role edge departure.
LB TJ Dottery	LSU	● ↓ Starting/major linebacker role departs.
DL Zxavian Harris	NFL attempt; later portal re-entry	● ↓ Major 2025 contributor leaves after a complicated pro/portal path.

Out	To	Loss
S Kapena Gushiken	NFL (Philadelphia), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 2025 starting safety leaves on a confirmed UDFA path.
S Wydett Williams Jr.	NFL (Arizona), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 2025 starting safety leaves for Arizona.

Defensive net: ● ↓ high-end anchors remain, but replacement risk is concentrated at safety and along the front

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Fast, physical offense emphasizing the run game, explosiveness and versatile tight ends rather than a full schematic reinvention.	Proven QB/RB pairing of QB Trinidad Chambliss and RB Kewan Lacy, plus returning OL experience.	Receiver target hierarchy is transfer-heavy after several material departures.
Defense	Golding-called defense with Brown coordinating a physical, fast, smart approach focused on limiting explosives and manufacturing pressure through the group.	DT Will Echoles, DE Kam Franklin, LB Suntarine Perkins and both returning corners provide high-leverage anchors.	Safety replaces three starters and the front seven must absorb several material departures.
Special teams	Returning specialist strength led by K Lucas Carneiro and P Oscar Bird.	SP+ special teams is No. 1; both specialists carry major recognition.	Long-snapper turnover is the main operation uncertainty.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● A-	● ↔	High	QB Trinidad Chambliss returns after a high-end 2025 season.
RB	● A	● ↔	High	RB Kewan Lacy returns as the proven offensive centerpiece.
WR	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Deuce Alexander anchors a room replacing several major targets.
TE	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Brady Prieskorn offsets the departure of TE Dae'Quan Wright.
OL	● B+	● ↔	Medium	OL Patrick Kutas anchors a line with useful returning experience.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↓	Medium-low	DT Will Echoles anchors a front replacing several major contributors.
LB	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	LB Suntarine Perkins returns, with LB Keaton Thomas adding proven volume.
Secondary	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	S Joenel Aguero joins a safety group replacing three starters.
Special teams	● A-	● ↔	High	SP+ special teams is No.1; Carneiro has national All-America/watchlist recognition and Bird is on the Ray Guy watchlist.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	New titles add transition risk, but both play-callers are established.
Overall	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	Top-20 caliber with a high-end offensive backfield; playoff-level ceiling but less continuity than the 2025 result suggests

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ Kewan Lacy	RB	● National star	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 1st team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Doak Walker · Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	Returns after 1,567 rushing yards and 24 rushing TD; the most proven offensive centerpiece.
★ Trinidad Chambliss	QB	● High-end national starter	AP 2nd team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	Started the final 13 games in 2025 and returns after 3,937 passing yards, 22 TD and 3 INT.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Will Echoles	DT	● National-impact interior defender	AP 2nd team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Bednarik · Nagurski · Outland	Returning defensive-line anchor after 68 tackles and 11.5 TFL in 2025.
Suntarine Perkins	LB	● High-end conference starter	SEC Coaches 2nd team · SEC Media 2nd team · Nagurski	Clear returning linebacker starter and one of the defense's safest high-leverage pieces.
Kam Franklin	DE	● High-end conference starter	SEC Coaches 3rd team · SEC Media 3rd team	Returning starting edge and a key bridge through front-seven turnover.
Deuce Alexander	WR	● Major-role returning receiver	-	Top returning receiver after 44 catches for 684 yards; his role is the stable point in a portal-heavy WR room.
Patrick Kutas	OL	● High-end conference lineman	SEC Coaches 3rd team · SEC Media 3rd team · Outland	Started all 15 games at right guard in 2025 and anchors an OL with real continuity despite transfer competition.
Lucas Carneiro	K	● National-impact specialist	AP 2nd team · Walter Camp 2nd team · SEC Coaches 2nd team · SEC Media 2nd team · Lou Groza	Returns after 31 made field goals and helps explain the No.1 SP+ special-teams signal.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Very hard; strong enough for playoff contention but with almost no low-cost margin after September
Difficulty	● 9/10 · Very hard · SP+ SOS No. 8
Hardest stretch	at Texas → Auburn → Georgia → at Oklahoma
Swing games	Louisville (neutral), at Florida, at Vanderbilt, Missouri, Auburn
Advantage	The Oct. 3 bye arrives before the SEC road trip to Vanderbilt; Wofford provides late-November relief before Mississippi State.
Expected	7.2 wins · most likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	A No.9 AP ranking can price Ole Miss like a proven playoff team even though SP+ is No.16 and the schedule is No.8; the useful angle is to distinguish stable backfield/special-teams strengths from less-settled WR/safety/front roles.
Back them when	The price does not demand elite-receiver continuity and the matchup lets Chambliss/Lacy stay balanced rather than chase obvious passing downs.
Fade/pass when	Asked to lay a premium against teams with strong pass games or fronts before the new safety/receiver hierarchies prove themselves.
Key monitor	WR target order beyond Deuce Alexander, final OL five, safety pairing, front-seven pass-rush distribution, Zxavian Harris / Dae'Quan Wright / Wydett Williams Jr. late eligibility status
Week 1 baseline	Ole Miss -5.5 vs. Louisville (neutral) · rating-only baseline; Ole Miss primer +16.5 minus Louisville primer +11.0; no home-field, matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Ole Miss -6.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Ole Miss still has a playoff-level ceiling because QB Trinidad Chambliss and RB Kewan Lacy headline an elite backfield, and special teams is a genuine strength. The larger questions sit at receiver and across a defense replacing important front and safety production.

That makes the Rebels a strong but less continuous version of the 13-win team. With SP+ No. 16 and SOS No. 8, **7.2 wins and 7-5** is a cautious baseline despite the No. 9 AP ranking.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [camp update](#) · [roster roles](#) · [departures](#) · [2025 context](#) · [current update](#) · [current update 2](#)

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